



◀ FOCUS ON EDUCATION

The Meiji government built schools throughout the country to increase literacy levels and create an educated workforce. All boys and girls had to attend elementary school. The lessons encouraged harmony between people and loyalty to the Japanese nation and to the emperor.

FACT

The word Meiji means “enlightened rule.” It was chosen as the name for Mutsuhito’s reign to mark the start of a new era in Japanese history.

MILITARY MIGHT ▶

In 1905, Japanese forces drove the Russians out of Manchuria (in northern China), proving that Japan was now a major world power.

One of the major clashes of the Russo-Japanese War (1904–1905), the Battle of Tsushima was the first sea battle fought between modern steel battleships.

Japanese battleships



EVERYDAY LIFE

Most workers in Japan’s booming textile factories were women and children. The conditions were harsh; they worked long hours for low pay, and slept in crowded dormitories where disease spread quickly.

